

We are at the second level at the Pullela Gopichand Academy, and the former world No. 1 pair is in the middle of a gruelling two-hour training session, first sparring with duo Dhruv Kapila and M.R. Arjun and then retrieving hard smashes from players acting as 'feeders'. SatChi play an aggressive, fast and attractive brand of badminton. It's been working wonders, especially in the past two years since Mathias Boe, a former Olympic silver medalist in doubles, took charge. (The Dane is married to actress Taapsee Pannu. SatChi were guests at their very private wedding.)

It's Boe's week off, but the shuttlers aren't taking their foot off the gas. What would be different if Boe was on court, we ask. "You'd have heard a lot of abuse," says Chirag, as Satwik nods and grins, "in English, Danish, and Hindi too, but in a very funny way. If someone is not ready for a stroke, he goes mad." Boe's planning and strategies have turned the spirited boys into sturdy men. Always seen as shuttlers with abundant talent, they have grown to become a formidable pair under his mentorship. "With him, it doesn't matter how long you are playing [on court], what really matters is the quality and effort you are putting in. You have to be 100 per cent on court," notes Chirag. For Satwik, it's Boe's emphasis on the "small things". "We have become more consistent. Now, even on a bad day, we can win a few matches," he adds.

They are now known for their variety and smart play. Equally adept at quick, flat exchanges at the net as at their powerful smashes, there's an all-roundedness to their game. The flick serve's one weapon in their arsenal, the returns often point winners. "Earlier, our only game was attack, there was no plan B as such," says Shetty. "Now, we make opponents play at our pace. That's how you dictate terms on court."

It shows in the results too. In 2024, they include the Thailand Open and French Open titles, the latter held at the same venue where the Olympic matches will be held. For SatChi, it's truly Paris *je t'aime*, having won the title twice and finished runners-up once. This time, when they head to the city of love, all eyes will be on them. "Obviously, we like the limelight, but we don't dwell too much on it," says Shetty. "We want to go there and enjoy. Whenever we have been positive, however bad or good the circumstances are, it has turned out really well for us." Badminton has given India three Olympic medals, but all in women's singles. If the shirts come off and there are dance moves on the court, know the number will be four. ■

–Suhani Singh

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